SkillNavora

HANDBOOK 4

Journey Builder and Automation Studio

Entry sources, activities, splits, re-entry, testing, activities, scheduling and monitoring.

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Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 11: Journey Builder

Level: Intermediate. Journeys: entry sources, activities, splits, testing and troubleshooting.

Module 11

11.1 Entry sources and activities

WHAT IS IT?

> A journey starts with an entry source (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience) and moves contacts through activities: email, SMS, push, wait, decision splits, engagement splits, random splits and update contact.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Journeys deliver the multi-step experiences customers expect, from welcome series to renewal reminders.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose an entry source that updates in near real time for triggered journeys.
2. Add an email activity and a wait activity.
3. Add a decision split on a data field (for example, plan type).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Welcome journey: entry on sign-up, welcome email, wait 2 days, decision split on first login.

COMMON ERRORS

Entering contacts from a data extension that is refreshed once a week and expecting real-time triggers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an entry source and how do you choose one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a three-step welcome journey on paper with entry, email, wait and a split.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Journey Builder documentation (Salesforce)

Module 11

11.2 Re-entry, exit criteria and testing

WHAT IS IT?

> Re-entry rules decide whether a contact can enter again. Exit criteria stop contacts who have completed or unsubscribed. Test with a test data extension before activating.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A wrong re-entry rule either floods a contact with messages or stops them from ever re-entering.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Set re-entry rules explicitly.
2. Add an exit on unsubscribe.
3. Test with a small test population, then review contact tracking.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Abandoned cart: re-entry allowed after 7 days, exit when the order completes.

COMMON ERRORS

Leaving re-entry at default without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot a journey that does not accept contacts?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the test plan for an abandoned cart journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 12: Automation Studio

Level: Intermediate. Automations: SQL activities, file imports, scheduling and monitoring.

Module 12

12.1 Activities and scheduling

WHAT IS IT?

> An automation is a sequence of activities such as SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification and send activities, run on a schedule or on file arrival.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automations prepare audiences and keep data current without manual work.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the automation, add a SQL Query Activity, then a Data Extract if needed.
2. Set a schedule (daily at 02:00 for example).
3. Run once manually before scheduling.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Daily: import file, run audience query, filter, then send.

COMMON ERRORS

Scheduling before testing the SQL; failures then happen unattended.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you schedule a daily audience build?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Plan an automation with four activities and an order.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 12

12.2 Monitoring, errors and retries

WHAT IS IT?

> Automation status shows which activity failed. Verification activities check files or row counts before the next step. Failure notifications and logs help support teams.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Production failures need fast detection and a clear path back to working data.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Add a verification step after each import.
2. Set failure notifications to the owner.
3. Keep a rerun procedure.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A verification step stops the send if the file has fewer than 1,000 rows.

COMMON ERRORS

No row-count checks, so an empty file sends an empty campaign.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot an automation failure?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a runbook for a failed daily import.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Quick reference: Journey Builder and Automation Studio

Area	Items
Journey Builder	Entry sources (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience); activities (email, SMS, push, wait, update contact); splits (decision, engagement, random); exit criteria; re-entry rules.
Automation Studio	SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification, send and wait activities; schedule and file-trigger starts.